

Demythologizing Luck

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Introduction

Human beings once called luck by the name of a god. Why does one person gain while another loses? Why does the careful person fail while the reckless person succeeds? Why is effort often unrewarded, while accident sometimes appears to yield reward? Faced with such fluctuations in distribution, human beings gave a face to what they could not fully explain. One such face was Fortuna. Myth was not merely a decorative veil over ignorance; rather, it was a form through which human beings endured a reality too complex to grasp in its entirety.

Yet even after the decline of mythic worldviews, the word luck did not disappear. We still say that someone is lucky or unlucky. This persistence suggests that the problem was never simply the existence of gods. Rather, it concerns the structure of human life itself. Human beings cannot fully possess the causal totality of the world, yet they cannot refrain from assigning meaning to outcomes. Luck, on this view, is neither a surviving superstition nor a purely objective property of events. It is a human response to the gap between finite understanding and complex reality.

This paper argues that luck should be demythologized, not abolished. To demythologize luck is not to deny its importance, but to relocate it: from divine agency to the sphere of human evaluation. More precisely, luck will be redefined here as a retrospective evaluative name assigned to a process that cannot be fully explained. Such a view allows us to preserve the experiential force of luck while resisting its reification as a mystical entity.

The inquiry proceeds in seven steps. First, I trace the movement from Fortuna to modern contingency. Second, I examine how luck functions in narratives of success and wealth, especially where resentment emerges. Third, I distinguish luck from absurdity and injustice. Fourth, I analyze the retrospective nature of luck as naming. Fifth, I ask whether luck can in any sense be “invited.” Sixth, I consider what it means to live with luck. Finally, I conclude by clarifying the philosophical meaning of demythologizing luck.

1. From Fortuna to Contingency

Reflection on luck begins within myth. In the ancient world, human life appeared radically unstable, and there seemed to be a frequent gap between effort and result. One person lost despite prudence; another gained despite coarseness or recklessness. Rather than treating this mismatch as mere confusion, human beings named it. Fortuna was one of those names. She was not simply a guarantor of happiness, but a symbolic figure for the fluctuation of allotment itself. Within this framework, luck appeared as something arriving from beyond ordinary causal control.

This mythic understanding should not be dismissed too quickly as intellectual naivety. It already contains a significant insight: human beings cannot fully grasp the total process by which outcomes are distributed. Fortuna may thus be read not merely as a superstitious fiction, but as a form for bearing the untrackability of life. Myth personified what could not be fully understood, giving a face, will, and narrative shape to what otherwise remained opaque. In this sense, myth was not only false explanation;

it was also an existential structure for enduring the unmasterable.

With modernity, however, luck gradually shifted away from divine personhood and toward secular vocabularies such as chance, probability, environment, and condition. Success came to be understood not solely in terms of talent or effort, but also in terms of birth, timing, education, capital, social institutions, and the contingencies of encounter. Luck was no longer the decree of a goddess, but the name for those dimensions of causality that remain difficult to track, integrate, or master. The mythic figure disappeared, but explanatory excess did not. What remained was luck in anonymous form.

This shift did not eliminate luck; it transformed its location. In myth, luck was a personal external force. In modernity, it became an impersonal process. Yet both share a common experiential core: the sense that one's life is never fully governed by one's own intentions or efforts. Luck names the point at which human beings encounter the limits of their control. The death of Fortuna did not produce the disappearance of luck, but its anonymization.

This anonymized luck becomes particularly visible in discussions of success and wealth. Narratives of achievement are often told as stories of talent, discipline, and decision. Yet they invariably include contingencies: historical timing, social conditions, unexpected encounters,

institutional structures, and favorable circumstances. At the same time, if contingency is emphasized too strongly, effort and agency appear erased. The discourse of luck emerges precisely in this tension. It mediates between what can be credited to the person and what must be attributed to forces that exceed personal mastery.

For this reason, luck cannot be treated only as an objective feature of events. It is also bound up with evaluation. To call something “luck” is not merely to describe it; it is already to interpret it. The concept survived demythologization because it names not only the opacity of the world, but also the evaluative posture from which human beings confront that opacity.

2. Success, Wealth, and Evaluation: When Luck Gives Rise to Ressentiment

Luck functions with particular sharpness in contexts of success and wealth. Wealth, status, and public achievement are visible and easily comparable. Unlike inner depth or moral seriousness, they present themselves as recognizable differences. When confronted with another person’s

success, one often asks, explicitly or implicitly: Why that person? Why not me? One answer is luck.

In such cases, “luck” does not operate as a purely neutral description. It has a double function. On the one hand, it may express a lucid recognition that success depends partly on contingent factors: timing, institutional opportunity, social position, the existence of favorable networks, and the ability to encounter the right opening at the right moment. On the other hand, the same word can serve as a strategy of evaluation, one that relativizes the worth of the successful person and protects the wounded self-esteem of the observer.

The successful person, conversely, is often tempted to narrate success as the straightforward result of effort and ability. Such a narrative may be partly true, but it also tends to retroactively smooth over contingency. Victories that depended in part on unpredictable conjunctions are retold as if they had always been the necessary outcome of personal merit. Thus, the unsuccessful tend to overestimate the role of luck in others, while the successful tend to underestimate its role in themselves. This asymmetry is not accidental. It is rooted in the evaluative tensions that structure human comparison.

This is why luck becomes philosophically important in relation to resentment. Another’s success does not appear as a mere external fact. It often reflects back upon the self as a

disturbance. Wealth especially has this power, because it simultaneously displays what another has and what one lacks. In such situations, the statement “he was just lucky” can function as consolation, but also as a subtle form of revenge. It can neutralize the superior standing of the other by relocating the source of that standing in accident rather than worth.

Yet the opposite distortion is equally problematic. When the successful person narrates the self as complete self-cause, the result is not realism but self-mythologization. The contingencies of birth, social order, historical timing, embodiment, and relational support vanish behind an exaggerated image of autonomy. Luck, then, becomes hidden not because it is absent, but because it is politically or psychologically inconvenient.

Accordingly, the concept of luck in such contexts is never merely descriptive. It is also an index of evaluative struggle. To invoke luck is to negotiate one’s relation to another’s success, and thus to negotiate one’s own standing. This is where resentment enters. Luck becomes a device through which the pain of comparison is managed, displaced, or weaponized.

A philosophical account of luck must therefore address not only the explanatory role of contingency but also the affective and evaluative structures within which the word operates. Luck is not simply about what happened. It is

about how human beings interpret what happened in relation to value, dignity, envy, and self-protection.

3. Luck, Absurdity, and Injustice: Distinguishing Three Forms of Instability

A proper account of luck requires distinguishing it from neighboring concepts that are often conflated with it. People frequently speak of “bad luck” whenever events turn out badly. Yet not every unwanted event belongs to the domain of luck. Some events remain connected to the intersection of choice and contingency, while others exceed that field altogether. To clarify luck, we must distinguish it from absurdity and injustice.

Luck, in the sense proposed here, refers to instability arising at the point of contact between human action and contingent circumstance. A chance meeting, a delay of several minutes, a fleeting first impression, a small decision whose consequences later widen into major divergence—these are typical cases. Luck is not simply an external object falling upon passive subjects. It emerges where human dispositions, choices, and openings encounter an environment that responds contingently.

For this reason, luck is shaped by context. Human beings live in environments that reward different kinds of openings. In one setting, sociability may create opportunities; in another, quiet seriousness may invite trust. First impressions are a revealing example. They are not the essence of a person, yet they often alter the quantity and quality of subsequent possibilities. In this sense, first impressions are not luck itself, but a technique by which the opening through which luck may enter is widened or narrowed.

Absurdity is different. Absurdity refers to events that intrude largely independently of one's accumulated choices and efforts and that resist meaningful integration. Illness, disaster, loss, rupture, and the brute experience of "why me?" belong here. Absurdity is not simply the absence of causal transparency. It is reality insofar as it refuses meaning. It is the moment at which the world fails to answer the human demand for intelligibility.

Injustice is different again. Injustice refers not merely to opacity but to imbalance that violates a normative expectation of fairness. When the honest are punished, the irresponsible rewarded, the powerless burdened, or the loud privileged, one does not simply face meaninglessness. One faces a distribution that refuses justification. If absurdity names an existential rupture, injustice names an ethical rupture.

Thus, the three concepts must be distinguished. Luck concerns the intersection of choice and contingency. Absurdity concerns the refusal of meaning. Injustice concerns the refusal of justification. The distinction matters because human beings often misclassify one for another. They may internalize absurdity or injustice as if it were simply their bad luck, thereby taking responsibility for what ought not be privatized. Conversely, if all luck is treated as absurdity or injustice, then the subtle role of openings, dispositions, and contingent encounters disappears.

To think philosophically about luck is therefore not merely to affirm contingency. It is to discern what belongs to one's openings, what belongs to the intrusion of the world, and what belongs to normatively distorted distribution. Such discernment can never be perfect, but its pursuit is central to the demythologization of luck.

4. Retrospection and Naming: When Does Luck Emerge?

Luck does not exist for us primarily as something immediately present in the middle of an event. Rather, luck

typically emerges after the event, or at least after its outcome has become visible. In the midst of living, one chooses, hesitates, reacts, endures, and proceeds. One does not usually stand outside the process and calmly declare: this is luck. Luck arises retrospectively, through a backward gaze that rereads the process in light of the outcome.

In this sense, luck is essentially retrospective. Suppose a favorable first impression leads later to a new opportunity. In retrospect one says, “I was lucky,” or “It was fortunate that I responded that way.” But at the moment itself there was only a gesture, tone, or encounter—not “luck” as such. Luck emerges only when the outcome illuminates selected features of the preceding process and assigns them significance. Luck is thus the name given to a process after the fact, once the process has been reconfigured under the light of a result.

This retrospective structure reveals that results do not merely end events; they reorganize them. Human beings narratively reconstruct the path leading to an outcome. When things go well, what once seemed accidental becomes “timing” or “fate” or “flow.” When things go badly, minor decisions are elevated into decisive turning points. Through such narrative reconstruction, processes that were complex and ungraspable in the moment become readable as meaningful sequences. Luck is not therefore merely another word for chance; it is also a byproduct of retrospective ordering.

This does not mean that luck is mere illusion. The human condition is such that life cannot be fully understood in real time. The total interplay of choices, reactions, social structures, accidents, and environmental shifts always exceeds available comprehension. Meaning is therefore often assigned after the fact. Luck emerges from this epistemic finitude. It is a necessary mode of organizing experience for beings who cannot fully grasp causal totality while living through it.

Expressions such as “good luck” and “bad luck” should therefore be understood not as direct access to metaphysical truth, but as markers of human positioning toward outcomes. When someone says “I was lucky,” they ordinarily acknowledge that a favorable result emerged from a process they cannot fully explain. When they say “I was unlucky,” they acknowledge an unfavorable result that likewise exceeds transparent causal ownership. Luck is thus not a substitute for causality, but an intermediate evaluative language used when causality cannot be completely possessed.

Luck is, in short, a naming practice. But naming here does not imply emptiness. To name is to locate oneself in relation to an event. The word luck preserves the sense that something more than effort alone was at stake, and that something more than negligence alone was involved. Human beings cannot live by total self-responsibilization, nor can they live by surrendering everything to chance. Luck occupies the unstable middle between these extremes.

For this reason, luck has a double significance. On the one hand, it expresses epistemic humility: not everything can be attributed to personal agency. On the other hand, it can become an evasion: if all failure is bad luck and all success good luck, then responsibility, discernment, and practice vanish. To use the concept of luck well, one must preserve what remains unexplained without turning explanation itself into an impossibility.

Accordingly, luck may now be defined more precisely: it is a retrospective evaluative name that human beings assign to a process they cannot fully explain. Such a definition preserves both the lived force of luck and its human, interpretive character.

5. Can Luck Be Invited? Openings, Techniques, and Contact with Contingency

Once luck has been defined as a retrospective evaluative concept, a further question arises: can human beings in any sense invite luck? If luck is not simply a mystical force but a name assigned to complex processes, then perhaps human beings can relate to those processes in ways that matter.

It must first be said that contingency itself cannot be controlled. One cannot command the arrival of a meeting, the emergence of a favorable historical moment, or the appearance of a particular opportunity. Any suggestion that luck can be manufactured at will risks a return to magical thinking. Demythologizing luck requires refusing the fantasy of sovereign command over contingency.

Yet it does not follow that nothing can be done. Although one cannot create contingency, one can alter the conditions under which one comes into contact with it. Human beings can position themselves differently with respect to possible openings. Some speak; others remain silent. Some close themselves to what is unfamiliar; others leave a small space open. Some repeat only familiar paths; others take limited risks. These differences do not produce luck mechanically, but they can affect the extent to which contingent possibility is able to enter into one's life.

In this sense, luck is not pure passivity. The language of "inviting luck" can be retained, provided it is understood in a non-magical way. Human beings do not summon contingency as such; rather, they shape the openings through which contingency may become consequential. First impressions are again instructive. They do not determine truth or moral worth, but they influence how others respond, whether trust begins to form, and whether further contact becomes possible. Thus, first impressions

may be described as initial conditions that alter the permeability of life to luck.

These openings are not morally uniform. What invites possibility in one environment may obstruct it in another. Frankness may open one context, while restraint may better sustain another. Sociability may generate contact in one setting, while quiet reliability may matter more in another. There is therefore no universal manual for “creating luck.” The relevant issue is always how a given environment recognizes and responds to certain kinds of human disposition.

This contextuality also explains why people often misunderstand their own luck. A mode of comportment that worked well in one setting may fail in another, producing the impression that one’s luck has changed. In many cases, however, what has changed is not “luck” in itself but the evaluative structure of the environment. A person may appear suddenly fortunate not because their essence transformed, but because their dispositions and the demands of a new context happened to resonate.

This account prevents the reduction of luck to effort. One can refine openings, cultivate responsiveness, and become more prepared to receive what arrives. But none of this guarantees outcomes. Effort does not abolish contingency. Yet neither is effort irrelevant. Luck is best understood as

arising at the boundary where disciplined human disposition encounters what remains beyond discipline.

To say, then, that luck may be invited is to say something modest but real: one cannot command contingency, but one can become more available to it. Luck is neither fully given nor fully made. It occupies an intermediate position between the world's unpredictability and the human shaping of openings through which the unpredictable may matter.

6. How to Live with Luck: Responsibility, Acceptance, and Disposition

Reflection on luck ultimately becomes reflection on how a human being ought to live. If everything is luck, then effort and responsibility dissolve. If luck is nothing, then individuals are forced to bear the full burden of a reality that far exceeds their control. Both extremes distort the texture of life. The more adequate question is not whether luck exists instead of responsibility, but how one might live with luck without surrendering responsibility.

This requires a proper delimitation of responsibility. Human beings can assume responsibility for their choices, habits, attitudes, and cultivated dispositions. They cannot assume total responsibility for every result, since results are always co-formed by others, structures, timing, environment, and contingent events. If responsibility is expanded too far, absurdity and injustice are internalized as personal failure. If responsibility is contracted too far, reflection and agency disappear. A mature disposition therefore accepts responsibility for the openings one shapes, while recognizing limits regarding what intrudes from beyond those openings.

Such recognition is not resignation. To admit that some things cannot be controlled is not to become passive, but to become more exact. One must distinguish what remains open to practice from what exceeds practice. To live well with luck is not to kneel before chance, but to resist confusing uncontrollability with total helplessness. Acceptance, here, is not abandonment. It is the wisdom of calibrating force to the nature of what confronts one.

At the center of this lies disposition. Disposition is not simply mood; it is a durable orientation toward the world. Some close themselves habitually to contingency; some open themselves without discernment; others remain receptive while retaining form. These differences do not guarantee outcomes, but they shape how contingency is met when it appears. Disposition is not the producer of luck, but the field in which luck becomes receivable or unreceivable.

Two errors must be avoided. The first is arrogance: the belief that one can master all outcomes and credit all success to oneself. This erases contingency, others, and structural support. The second is fatalism: the belief that everything is merely luck. This erases learning, cultivation, and the significance of formed disposition. To live with luck is to refuse both the fantasy of total control and the fantasy of pure helplessness.

This has implications for how we see others as well. Another person's success need not be worshipped as pure merit, nor dismissed as pure accident. Another person's failure need not be reduced to laziness, nor absorbed into impersonal misfortune. To understand luck is to grant that every life is formed through complex intersections of agency and contingency. Such recognition does not abolish envy or judgment, but it can make them less crude. In place of simplistic praise or blame, one may cultivate respect for complexity.

Ultimately, to live with luck is to continue living without total explanatory possession. Human beings choose without complete knowledge, act without guaranteed results, and narrate their lives only after the fact. What remains possible is not mastery, but form: to cultivate receptivity without illusion, responsibility without cruelty, and humility without collapse. One does not wait passively for luck; one becomes able to receive what contingency offers without mythologizing it.

Thus a mature attitude toward luck may be stated simply: acknowledging contingency does not require abandoning responsibility, and taking responsibility does not require denying contingency. Only within this tension can a human being understand why the word luck remains necessary even after its demythologization.

Conclusion: What Does It Mean to Demythologize Luck?

This paper began from an ordinary word and treated it as a site where myth, contingency, and evaluation intersect. Luck was once personified in figures such as Fortuna. Human beings, unable to explain why some gained while others lost, attributed such distribution to divine or quasi-divine agency. Yet even after the withdrawal of these mythic frameworks, luck remained. This persistence reveals that luck is not simply a relic of superstition, but an enduring mode through which finite beings confront complex outcomes.

To demythologize luck, then, is not to deny it. It is to reinterpret it. Luck is not a mystical force descending from

outside history. Nor is it merely a trivial label for randomness. It is a retrospective evaluative name assigned to processes that cannot be fully explained. It belongs to the human condition of living amid causal excess while still needing to assign meaning to what has happened.

This reinterpretation required conceptual differentiation. Luck was distinguished from absurdity and injustice. Absurdity names reality insofar as it refuses meaning. Injustice names distribution insofar as it refuses justification. Luck, by contrast, belongs to the unstable region where human openings meet contingent response. This distinction helps prevent the flattening of all misfortune into bad luck, while preserving the specific domain in which luck remains philosophically significant.

The inquiry also showed that luck is inseparable from value. In narratives of success and wealth, luck functions both as explanatory concept and as evaluative weapon. It may register contingency with honesty, but it may also express envy, self-protection, or resentment. Thus the demythologization of luck is also a clarification of the human affective structures within which the word operates.

Finally, luck was shown to be linked not only to passively endured accident but also to openings and disposition. Human beings cannot command contingency, yet they can shape the conditions under which contingency becomes meaningful in their lives. In this sense, luck occupies an

intermediate position between what is given and what may, without illusion, be invited.

What, then, does it mean to demythologize luck? It means refusing both magical reification and reductive dismissal. It means returning luck from divine agency to human finitude, from metaphysical force to evaluative structure, from mythic personhood to lived interpretation. Luck is not thereby abolished. Rather, it is brought back within the limits and needs of human life.

If this paper has succeeded, it has not destroyed the word luck, but rendered it more exact. Demythologizing luck means understanding why human beings still require this word after the gods are gone: because they remain finite beings who must live, judge, and continue without ever fully possessing the processes that shape their lives.